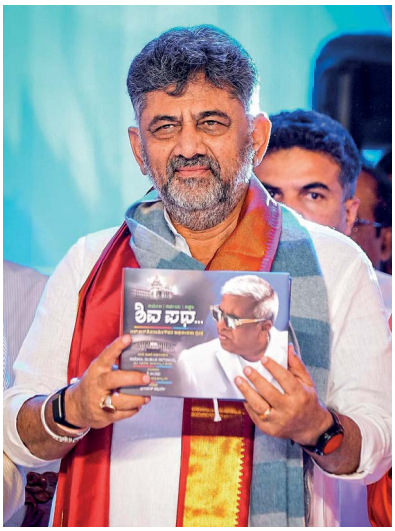


ANI

MAN ON A MISSION D.K. Shivakumar at a book launch, Bengaluru, Jul. 4

While delayed payments have occasionally been flagged, the reported discrepancies invited Opposition flak. "Where is the money going? Payments have been made to fake accounts," charged the BJP's R. Ashoka, Leader of Opposition. DKS, who ordered tighter oversight in a mid-June review, was matter of fact: "Some people created fake records in the names of deceased persons and are availing the benefits. Therefore, beneficiaries have been asked to reapply so that their details can be verified and authenticated. There is nothing more to it."

PROCEDURAL SNAFU?

Some of the reported discrepancies, officials explain, are connected to the lag in updating deaths in the database—an outgo of Rs 115 crore to 108,755 'ghost' beneficiaries who will cease to haunt the exchequer forthwith. Also, as many as 194,560 ineligible people had been weeded out by cross-verifying the rolls with income-tax and GST returns data, they add. Only women holding Antyodaya, Below Poverty Line or Above Poverty Line ration cards and who aren't taxpayers are eligible under Gruha Lakshmi.

Though the database is partly clouded by multiple accounts or joint accounts held by close relatives—say, a mother and daughter—officials of the Women and Child Development department say Aadhaar-based payment minimises irregularities.

The DKS dispensation has separately embarked on a door-to-door drive to verify the 16.5 million households enrolled under the free power scheme, Gruha Jyothi. Together, Karnataka has this year earmarked Rs 39,186 crore for Gruha Lakshmi and Gruha Jyothi, which represent three-fourths of the FY27 outlay of Rs 51,286 crore for the five guarantees that also include free ration, free bus rides for women and an unemployment dole for graduates. "It has provided succour. Studies reveal that the schemes helped families with expenditure on food, healthcare and basic education," says L.K. Atheeq, finance advisor to the CM. There will no cutback, only streamlining, he adds.

Takeaways

- **The DKS govt tightens beneficiary verification to plug leakages in flagship welfare schemes**
- **Audits have flagged irregularities in Gruha Lakshmi, including payments to deceased and ineligible beneficiaries**

The flipside? The inflexibility it has created in the state's overall expenditure, with investment on public infrastructure taking a hit. Even the ongoing surveys to reverify beneficiaries aren't expected to result in major expenditure savings—officials reckon it could free up Rs 3,000-4,000 crore at best. For the DKS government, which is prioritising rural infrastructure, connectivity and urban development, savings on committed expenditure, however little, will be welcome. ■

By **Prasad Nichenametla**

JAGAN MOHAN REDDY has once had to endure life in harsh confinement. Few know that, had he remained in power after the 2024 election, he would have been cocooned in the most opulent residence-cum-office of any CM—or, for that matter, even the PM. Plush bathrooms bigger than the average Mumbai 2BHK, a gym double that size at 1,096 square feet, spa, jacuzzi, game room, kingsize bedrooms at 650 sq. ft, all done up lavishly and cooled by multi-tonne central air-conditioning. That's just 'Vijayanagara', the block that was to have served as the CM's 12-room living quarters.

The other three blocks were named after the greatest kingdoms of these parts—Vengi, Kalinga, Gajapathi. These too were outfitted with spacious suites, conference halls, banquet halls, cafes, restaurant, studio... what have you. All this was when Jagan, during his 2019-24 tenure as CM, was evolving his plan to turn around Chandrababu Naidu's dream of a new capital at Amaravati to a controversial three-capital formula. The executive capital, and hence his own camp office, was to be here in coastal Visakhapatnam.



JAGAN'S JAM

The result: the ultimate sovereign citadel, a 10-acre perch carved out of the Rushikonda hill with a panoramic view of the Bay of Bengal at a cut-rate price of Rs 450 crore. The palatial G+1 structure, crouched atop an Eastern Ghat ridge above a popular beach spot, was originally planned to be a resort for the rich as work began under the aegis of the AP Tourism Development Corporation (APTDC). However, in late 2023, as Jagan announced his CMO would soon shift to Vizag, a government panel recognised it as a place fit to serve as Jagan's workcation-cum-sanctuary.